Declaration of Sentiments

Seneca Falls Convention · July 19–20, 1848 · principal author: Elizabeth Cady Stanton

Source: Declaration of Sentiments (Seneca Falls, 1848), as printed in Stanton, Anthony & Gage, History of Woman Suffrage, vol. I (1881), text via Project Gutenberg (#28020). Public domain.

The Seneca Falls Convention in upstate New York is conventionally called the start of the organized American women's-rights movement. Elizabeth Cady Stanton and Lucretia Mott drafted the Declaration of Sentiments by deliberately rewriting the Declaration of Independence — substituting 'all men' with 'all men and women' and replacing the king's grievances with a list of injustices women suffered under men's law. About 300 people attended; 100 signed.

Connect: How did the Erie Canal (1825, Class 8 era) set up the Northern industrial economy you're reading about now?

Key Passages

Preamble (rewritten)

> We hold these truths to be self-evident: that all men and women are created equal; that they are endowed by their Creator with certain inalienable rights; that among these are life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness; that to secure these rights governments are instituted, deriving their just powers from the consent of the governed.

Sample grievances

> He has never permitted her to exercise her inalienable right to the elective franchise. He has compelled her to submit to laws, in the formation of which she had no voice. He has withheld from her rights which are given to the most ignorant and degraded men—both natives and foreigners.

Resolution on suffrage (carried narrowly, with Frederick Douglass's support)

> Resolved, That it is the duty of the women of this country to secure to themselves their sacred right to the elective franchise.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The antebellum reform era and the Second Great Awakening; women active in abolition were often barred from speaking, and married women had few legal rights.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Those at the Seneca Falls Convention and the broader American public, including lawmakers, newspapers, and fellow reformers.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Middle-class white women reformers led by Elizabeth Cady Stanton and Lucretia Mott; the concerns of working-class and enslaved Black women are largely missing.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Evidence (1 pt): Use this document plus ONE other reform-era source to argue that antebellum reform movements were interconnected.
2. Why did Stanton structure the document as a parody of the Declaration of Independence?
3. What does the narrow passage of the suffrage resolution suggest about reform politics in 1848?